

DSAT Reading & Writing — Main Purpose

25 Original Practice Questions | Easy · Medium · Hard

Q1.

[Easy]

Honeybees communicate the location of food sources through a behavior known as the waggle dance. A forager bee returning to the hive performs a figure-eight pattern, with the angle of the central 'waggle' run indicating the direction relative to the sun and the duration of the run corresponding to the distance. Other bees observe the dance and then fly directly to the food source.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To explain how honeybees use a specific behavior to share information about food locations
 - B) To argue that honeybees are more intelligent than other insect species
 - C) To compare the communication methods of honeybees with those of other social insects
 - D) To describe the life cycle of a honeybee forager from birth to maturity
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Q2.

[Easy]

The following text is from Clara Mwangi's 2020 short story collection *Sundown Roads*. The old fisherman sat at the end of the dock, mending his net with fingers that had not lost their swiftness despite the years. His grandson watched, trying to mimic the knots, but the boy's loops came undone as quickly as he tied them. 'Patience,' the old man said, without looking up. 'The net does not care how fast you work. It cares that you finish.'

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To describe the economic hardships faced by fishing communities
 - B) To criticize the grandson for failing to learn the fisherman's trade
 - C) To compare traditional fishing methods with modern technology
 - D) To illustrate a generational exchange in which an elder imparts a lesson about persistence
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Q3.

[Easy]

A public library in Portland, Oregon, recently eliminated overdue fines for all borrowers. Library officials reported that within six months, the number of active cardholders increased by 15 percent, and the rate at which overdue materials were returned actually rose. The program's supporters argue that fines disproportionately discourage low-income residents from using library services.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To argue that all public libraries should adopt identical fine policies
 - B) To present the results and rationale behind a library's decision to remove overdue fines
 - C) To explain the history of the public library system in the United States
 - D) To contrast the policies of urban libraries with those of rural libraries
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Q4.

[Easy]

The Silk Road was not a single road but a network of trade routes connecting East Asia with the Mediterranean. Merchants transported goods such as silk, spices, and precious metals across thousands of miles, but the routes also facilitated the exchange of ideas, religions, and technologies between civilizations that might otherwise have had little contact.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To argue that the Silk Road was primarily responsible for the spread of a single religion
 - B) To describe how the Silk Road facilitated both commercial and cultural exchange across distant regions
 - C) To explain why the Silk Road eventually fell out of use
 - D) To compare the Silk Road with modern international shipping networks
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Q5.

[Easy]

Venus flytraps capture insects using hinged leaves that snap shut when trigger hairs on their inner surfaces are touched. The plant requires two stimulations of the trigger hairs within approximately twenty seconds to close, a mechanism that prevents the trap from wasting energy on false alarms such as falling raindrops.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To compare Venus flytraps with other carnivorous plant species
 - B) To argue that Venus flytraps are endangered due to habitat loss
 - C) To explain why scientists classify Venus flytraps as animals rather than plants
 - D) To describe the trapping mechanism of Venus flytraps and explain how it avoids unnecessary activation
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Q6.

[Easy]

The following text is from Daniel Okwu's 2019 novel *Bridge of Reeds*. When the floodwaters rose, the village council debated whether to reinforce the old levee or abandon it and retreat to higher ground. Elder Nkechi listened to both sides and then reminded the council that the same debate had occurred forty years earlier, and that the levee builders had won then too. 'We chose the levee,' she said, 'and we have been repairing it ever since.'

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To celebrate the village council's effective response to natural disasters
 - B) To demonstrate that building levees is always preferable to relocating
 - C) To describe the engineering techniques used to construct the village's levee
 - D) To present a character's observation that a past decision has led to a recurring burden
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Q7.

[Easy]

Economist Rita Vasquez found that small businesses in walkable neighborhoods generate more revenue per square foot than comparable businesses on car-dependent commercial strips. Vasquez attributes this difference to higher pedestrian traffic, which increases the likelihood of impulse visits to shops and restaurants.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To present a researcher's finding that walkability benefits small-business revenue and to explain the proposed cause
 - B) To argue that car-dependent commercial areas should be demolished and rebuilt
 - C) To compare the profitability of small businesses with that of large corporations
 - D) To describe the methods economists use to measure pedestrian traffic
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Q8.

[Medium]

Migratory birds navigate using a variety of cues, including the position of the sun, the pattern of stars, and Earth's magnetic field. Ornithologist Hana Petrov recently demonstrated that European robins possess a protein called cryptochrome in their retinas that is sensitive to magnetic fields. Petrov's experiments showed that when cryptochrome function was disrupted chemically, the birds' ability to orient toward magnetic north declined significantly, though their use of solar and stellar cues remained unaffected.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To argue that European robins rely on magnetic fields more than any other navigational cue
 - B) To introduce a researcher's evidence that a specific protein enables magnetic navigation in a bird species
 - C) To compare the migratory routes of European robins with those of other bird species
 - D) To explain why migratory birds are declining in number across Europe
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Q9.

[Medium]

Though Harriet Jacobs's 1861 autobiography is now regarded as a landmark of American literature, it was largely overlooked for more than a century after its publication. Literary scholar Jean Fagan Yellin spent years verifying the text's authenticity and tracing its historical references, publishing a critical edition in 1987 that restored the work to scholarly attention. Yellin's efforts revealed the complexity of Jacobs's narrative strategies and established the autobiography as essential reading in courses on American history and literature.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To describe how a scholar's research rescued a neglected autobiography and demonstrated its literary significance
 - B) To argue that Harriet Jacobs's autobiography is superior to other works of nineteenth-century American literature
 - C) To explain the techniques Harriet Jacobs used to escape enslavement
 - D) To criticize scholars who failed to recognize the importance of Jacobs's work before Yellin's edition
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Q10.

[Medium]

When a forest fire burns through an ecosystem, it clears dead vegetation and returns nutrients to the soil, creating conditions favorable for new growth. Ecologist David Moreno has found, however, that the increasing frequency of fires in some Mediterranean regions is shortening the recovery interval to the point where soil nutrients are depleted faster than they can be replenished. Moreno warns that without longer intervals between fires, some ecosystems may shift permanently from forest to shrubland.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To advocate for the complete suppression of all forest fires in Mediterranean regions
 - B) To describe the chemical processes by which fire returns nutrients to soil
 - C) To explain that while fire can benefit ecosystems, excessively frequent fires may cause irreversible ecological change
 - D) To compare the fire ecology of Mediterranean regions with that of boreal forests
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Q11.

[Medium]

The following text is from Yuki Tanabe's 2022 poetry collection *Tidal Ledger*. She measured the days not by clocks but by the slow accumulation of shells along the windowsill—each one a journey completed by the tide and left behind. By August the sill was full, and she had to decide whether to make room for more or to accept that the collection was finished.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To provide a scientific account of how tidal patterns affect shell distribution on coastlines
 - B) To describe the speaker's plan to open a shop selling seashells
 - C) To use the image of collecting shells as a metaphor for the passage of time and the limits of accumulation
 - D) To argue that people should spend more time observing nature and less time watching clocks
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Q12.

[Medium]

Political scientist Amara Diallo examined voter turnout in local elections across twelve democracies and found that countries with compulsory voting laws had turnout rates averaging 89 percent, compared with 55 percent in countries without such laws. Diallo notes, however, that high turnout alone does not ensure representative outcomes; in some compulsory-voting countries, a significant share of ballots are cast blank or deliberately spoiled, suggesting that mandatory participation may not translate into engaged civic behavior.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To argue that all democracies should adopt compulsory voting laws
 - B) To explain the history of compulsory voting from its origins to the present day
 - C) To present evidence that compulsory voting increases turnout while noting that higher turnout does not necessarily indicate greater civic engagement
 - D) To demonstrate that voluntary voting systems produce more representative election outcomes than compulsory systems
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Q13.

[Medium]

During the construction of the Panama Canal in the early 1900s, tropical diseases—particularly malaria and yellow fever—killed thousands of workers and threatened to halt the project. Chief sanitary officer William Gorgas implemented an aggressive mosquito-control campaign, draining standing water and fumigating buildings across the Canal Zone. The campaign dramatically reduced disease-related deaths and allowed construction to proceed, demonstrating the practical impact of public-health measures on large-scale engineering projects.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To argue that the Panama Canal should not have been built because of its human cost
 - B) To describe the engineering challenges of digging through mountainous terrain
 - C) To illustrate how a public-health intervention was essential to the completion of a major engineering project
 - D) To compare the sanitation practices of the Panama Canal project with those of modern construction sites
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Q14.

[Medium]

Most animals that live at extreme ocean depths are small, but the giant isopod can reach lengths of over forty centimeters. Marine biologist Elena Rossi hypothesizes that deep-sea gigantism in isopods results from a combination of low predation pressure, cold temperatures that slow metabolism, and the adaptive advantage of a larger body for storing energy during long intervals between meals. Rossi acknowledges, however, that these factors alone may not fully explain the phenomenon, since other deep-sea crustaceans exposed to similar conditions remain small.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To present a hypothesis about why giant isopods grow unusually large while acknowledging that the explanation may be incomplete
 - B) To argue that deep-sea gigantism is caused exclusively by low predation pressure
 - C) To describe the diet and feeding habits of the giant isopod in detail
 - D) To compare the body sizes of all crustacean species found in deep-sea environments
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Q15.

[Medium]

The following text is from Omar Bello's 2015 novel *The Quiet Republic*. Augusto had always believed that silence was a form of consent, but after years of living in the capital he began to suspect it was something else entirely—a form of endurance. The people around him did not speak because they had nothing to say; they did not speak because the cost of speaking was too high, and silence was the only currency they could afford to spend.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To convey a character's evolving understanding of silence as a response to an oppressive social environment
 - B) To describe the economic conditions that make life in the capital difficult
 - C) To argue that silence is always a morally acceptable response to injustice
 - D) To contrast Augusto's personality with that of more outspoken characters in the novel
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Q16.

[Medium]

Anthropologist Keiko Yamamoto studied gift-exchange practices in three Pacific Island communities and found that the social status of the giver, rather than the monetary value of the gift, determined how recipients perceived the exchange. Gifts from community leaders were treated with greater reverence regardless of their material worth, while identical items from lower-status individuals received more modest acknowledgment. Yamamoto argues that these practices reveal how social hierarchies are reinforced through everyday rituals.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To criticize Pacific Island communities for maintaining rigid social hierarchies
 - B) To describe the types of gifts most commonly exchanged in Pacific Island cultures
 - C) To argue that gift exchange has been replaced by monetary transactions in most modern societies
 - D) To present research showing that the social meaning of gift exchange depends more on the giver's status than on the gift's value
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Q17.*[Medium]*

The Mpemba effect—the observation that, under certain conditions, hot water can freeze faster than cold water—has puzzled scientists for decades. Physicist Lena Borg recently proposed that the effect arises because heating alters the hydrogen-bond network in water, creating a molecular configuration that releases energy more rapidly during cooling. Borg's simulations support this mechanism, but experimental confirmation has proven difficult because the effect is sensitive to variables such as container shape and ambient humidity.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To argue that the Mpemba effect has been definitively explained by recent research
 - B) To introduce a proposed explanation for a long-standing scientific puzzle while noting that experimental verification remains challenging
 - C) To compare competing theories about the molecular structure of water
 - D) To describe the practical applications of the Mpemba effect in industrial refrigeration
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Q18.*[Hard]*

Conventional models of stellar evolution predict that stars below a certain mass threshold will end their lives as white dwarfs without undergoing a supernova explosion. Astrophysicist Ravi Chandrasekaran has identified a class of anomalous transient events in which low-mass stars appear to produce brief, luminous flares that share some spectroscopic signatures with supernovae but lack others, such as the characteristic emission lines of heavy elements. Chandrasekaran suggests these events may represent a previously unrecognized end-of-life pathway for certain low-mass stars, though he concedes that instrumental artifacts have not been conclusively ruled out.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To refute the conventional model of stellar evolution by providing definitive evidence of a new star type
 - B) To describe newly observed stellar events that may challenge existing models while acknowledging unresolved uncertainties
 - C) To explain the spectroscopic techniques astronomers use to classify supernova events
 - D) To argue that all low-mass stars eventually undergo supernova explosions
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Q19.

[Hard]

Historian Fatima Al-Rashid has re-evaluated the role of medieval Islamic hospitals, known as bimaristans, in the development of clinical medicine. While earlier Western scholarship often treated bimaristans as charitable institutions with minimal medical rigor, Al-Rashid's archival research reveals detailed patient records, systematic drug trials, and specialized wards organized by disease type—practices that preceded comparable European developments by several centuries. Al-Rashid does not claim that bimaristans were modern hospitals in disguise; rather, she argues that their contributions to evidence-based practice deserve fuller recognition in histories of medicine.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To present a historian's case that medieval Islamic hospitals were more medically sophisticated than earlier Western scholarship acknowledged
 - B) To argue that medieval Islamic hospitals were identical to modern hospitals in their practices and organization
 - C) To criticize Western historians for deliberately suppressing information about bimaristans
 - D) To describe the architectural features that distinguish bimaristans from European hospitals
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Q20.

[Hard]

Neuroscientist Tomoko Ishikawa has questioned whether the widely cited 'left brain / right brain' framework—which holds that analytical thinking is localized in the left hemisphere and creative thinking in the right—accurately reflects neural processing. Ishikawa's functional MRI studies show that both creative and analytical tasks activate distributed networks spanning both hemispheres, with the degree of lateralization varying substantially among individuals. She argues that while some neural functions are lateralized (e.g., language production), the popular dichotomy oversimplifies brain organization and may lead educators to design curricula around a misleading model.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To argue that neuroscience has no relevance to educational curriculum design
 - B) To explain how functional MRI technology was developed and refined over time
 - C) To present a researcher's evidence that the popular left-brain/right-brain dichotomy oversimplifies how the brain processes information
 - D) To compare Ishikawa's findings with those of researchers who support the left-brain/right-brain model
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Q21.

[Hard]

The following text is from Saoirse Brennan's 2018 essay collection *Borrowed Light*. I had expected grief to arrive all at once, like a wave, but instead it came in installments—a song on the radio, a handwriting sample on a grocery list, the particular way afternoon light fell across a chair no one sat in anymore. Each installment was small enough to survive, which was, I think, the only reason I survived them all.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To argue that grief is a universal experience that affects everyone identically
 - B) To provide advice to readers on how to cope with the loss of a loved one
 - C) To contrast the speaker's grief with the grief experienced by other family members
 - D) To describe the speaker's experience of grief as gradual and incremental rather than sudden
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Q22.

[Hard]

The standard model of superconductivity, proposed by Bardeen, Cooper, and Schrieffer, explains the phenomenon through the formation of electron pairs at very low temperatures. However, certain copper-oxide compounds become superconducting at temperatures far above those predicted by the standard model. Physicist Amina Kessler has proposed that in these materials, magnetic fluctuations rather than lattice vibrations mediate electron pairing. Kessler's model successfully predicts the transition temperatures of several known high-temperature superconductors, but it has yet to account for anomalies observed in newly synthesized nickel-oxide compounds.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To argue that the Bardeen-Cooper-Schrieffer model should be abandoned entirely
 - B) To introduce an alternative model of superconductivity that addresses limitations of the standard theory while noting its own unresolved challenges
 - C) To describe the industrial applications of high-temperature superconductors
 - D) To explain why nickel-oxide compounds are superior to copper-oxide compounds for superconductor manufacturing
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Q23.

[Hard]

Archaeological evidence from the site of Mohenjo-daro in present-day Pakistan reveals a remarkably uniform urban plan: streets arranged in a grid, standardized brick sizes across structures, and an elaborate drainage system. Archaeologist Prerna Malhotra argues that this uniformity implies a centralized planning authority, but she cautions against equating centralization with autocracy. Malhotra points out that the absence of palatial structures and monumental royal tombs at Mohenjo-daro suggests a governance model quite different from the hierarchical kingships of contemporary Mesopotamian cities.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To compare the architectural achievements of Mohenjo-daro with those of ancient Egyptian cities
 - B) To argue that Mohenjo-daro was governed by a single powerful king
 - C) To present an archaeologist's argument that Mohenjo-daro's uniform planning suggests centralized authority while distinguishing that authority from autocratic rule
 - D) To describe the methods archaeologists use to date bricks and drainage systems
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Q24.

[Hard]

Philosopher Kwame Asante has critiqued the notion of 'meritocracy' by arguing that what societies label as individual merit is often inseparable from structural advantages such as access to quality education, professional networks, and inherited wealth. Asante does not deny that talent and effort matter; rather, he contends that treating outcomes as purely merit-based obscures the role of systemic factors and can be used to justify existing inequalities as natural and deserved.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To present a philosopher's argument that the concept of meritocracy overlooks structural factors, potentially legitimizing inequality
 - B) To argue that talent and effort play no role in determining individual success
 - C) To provide a historical overview of how the term 'meritocracy' has been used across cultures
 - D) To compare Asante's views on inequality with those of classical economists
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Q25.

[Hard]

The following text is from Nikolai Avenov's 2021 novel *The Understory*. The botanist cataloged each species with the same meticulous care, whether it was a towering mahogany or a moss no larger than a thumbprint. His colleagues teased him for the hours he spent on organisms that would never appear in a textbook, but he maintained that significance was not the same as visibility. The forest, he believed, was held together not by its tallest trees but by the unseen threads connecting root to fungus to soil.

Which choice best describes the main purpose of the text?

- A) To describe the daily routine of a field botanist working in a tropical forest
 - B) To argue that textbooks should include more information about moss species
 - C) To criticize the botanist's colleagues for their lack of scientific curiosity
 - D) To convey a character's belief that overlooked organisms are as ecologically important as conspicuous ones
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